# Our Talking Circle

*Civic Skill: Voice & Participation | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 1 (Identity) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years*

## LEARNING INTENTION

Inspired by the 'Barn Yarns' practice described in the Voice of Children Framework, children will help create their own name and rituals for a regular circle space where they can raise things that matter to them, building ownership over their own participation structure.

## SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can help decide what our circle is called and how it works.
- I can bring something that matters to me to the circle.
- I can listen when someone else is speaking in the circle.

## MATERIALS

- A special circle mat or defined circle space
- A simple object to become the group's 'talking piece,' chosen and decorated by the children
- Materials to decorate the talking piece
- A picture book or story that reflects community and gathering, chosen in consultation with families and, where relevant, local Aboriginal community organisations

## ACTIVITY STEPS

**1. INTRODUCE THE IDEA (4 min):** 'In some places, people sit in circles and use a special object to know whose turn it is to talk. We're going to build our own.'

**2. BOOK SHARE (5 min):** Share a chosen story connecting to community gathering, introduced respectfully and, where possible, informed by input from a local cultural worker or Aboriginal Community Controlled Organisation.

**3. NAMING CIRCLE (6 min):** Children brainstorm names for their circle space and vote together on a favourite — let the name be genuinely theirs, even if unexpected.

**4. DECORATE THE TALKING PIECE (7 min):** As a group, decorate the object that will signal whose turn it is to speak.

**5. FIRST CIRCLE (6 min):** Use the circle for real: each child who wishes to may share one thing about the room this week while holding the talking piece. Others practise listening without interrupting.

**6. CLOSING (2 min):** Establish how the circle will be 'called' in future — a signal, a song, or a phrase the children choose.

## EXTENSIONS

- Use the talking circle regularly for real, ongoing issues in the room — not only for this lesson
- Where appropriate, connect with a local Aboriginal Community Controlled Organisation to guide culturally safe practice
- Let children 'call' a circle themselves when something matters to them, mirroring the Barn Yarns case study

## ASSESSMENT

- Observe turn-taking and respect for the talking piece
- Note which children initiate 'calling a circle' in the weeks that follow
- Learning story: document what the circle's name and rituals reveal about what matters to this group of children

## EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Was this activity delivered with appropriate cultural safety, and in genuine consultation with community where relevant?
- How will the talking circle be sustained as an everyday practice rather than a one-off activity?
- What did children choose to raise once they had a space that was genuinely theirs?

## EYLF LINKS

*This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 1 (Identity). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.*